Pudding

A dog companion that helps you stay focused

“Gentle companionship + nudges to reduce anxiety and help users start and sustain focus.”

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Problems

The Feedback Vacuum: Self-directed remote workers and students lose momentum during deep work because progress feels invisible and external validation is missing.

The Anxiety Loop: Traditional productivity tools rely on rigid tracking and guilt, which increases anxiety and triggers avoidance rather than helping.

High Startup Friction: Users struggle to initiate focus because the rigid setup of traditional timers feels like a demanding chore.

Solution: A Low-Pressure Desktop Companion

Value Proposition:

Pudding! empowers self-directed workers to overcome the "Anxiety Loop" by providing a non-judgmental, low-pressure presence that validates effort even when progress is invisible.

Ambient Desktop Presence:

A desktop-exclusive companion that provides a "social gaze" to maintain focus, utilizing Smart Dodging / Transparency so it never obstructs professional workspaces like Figma or VS Code.

Gentle Re-Entry Rituals:

Replaces rigid timers with neutral, judgment-free states (e.g., Pudding takes a "Nap" during breaks) to help users recover from distractions without triggering the Anxiety Loop or guilt.

Invisible Progress Validation:

Translates isolating, self-directed work sessions into ambient emotional support, closing the Feedback Vacuum without demanding high-friction inputs or performance tracking.

Simple

- **Task:** Initiate a 25-minute focus session by clicking a "Deepwork" preset.
- **Justification:** This is the most frequent action every user performs, and it requires only a single click with no decision-making. Making it the simplest possible interaction.
- **Change since GR5** : Removed the manual time-selection screen and replaced it with one-click Quick-Start Presets. Moved entirely to desktop.

Moderate

- **Task:** Break a goal into 2 to 4 steps and start Step 1 using the desktop companion.
- **Justification:** This is a core getting unstuck workflow. More involved than starting a timer because it requires lightweight planning + navigating multiple screens, but still common for real deep work.
- **Change since GR5** : Removed cross-platform flows and reduced "planning procrastination" by making step creation fast (templates / quick-add) and keeping the current step visible during the RUNNING state.

Complex

- **Task:** While a focus session is RUNNING, the user gets distracted, uses a nudge to recover (Resume / Nap / End), then ends the session and records a next step.
- **Justification:** Includes interruption as a state change, requires a recovery decision (branching), and ends with reflection (closing the loop) rather than just "timer ends."
- **Change since GR5:** Removed mobile flow confusion and redesigned interruption handling to be neutral (no guilt), with explicit states (RUNNING / NUDGED / NAP / ENDED) and a clear Summary to Reflection step so progress and next action are visible.

Testing Results: Goal 1: Reduce startup friction

Time-to-start

Metric: Time to start a focus session (from "Home" to "Timer Running").
Target: Under 30 seconds (to prevent the "Anxiety Loop").
Results:

- **Sara:** 12 seconds (Pass)
- **Skyler:** 15 seconds (Pass)
- **Tommy:** 45 seconds (Fail - slowed by text input).

Average Time: 24 seconds.
Verdict: Success. The "Quick Start" flow works for digital natives, but manual entry is a barrier for non-desk workers like Tommy.

Interaction cost

Metric: Interaction cost to start a focus session (number of actions from “Home” → “Timer RUNNING”).
Target: ≤ 3 actions (to keep the start flow lightweight and avoid “startup friction”).
Results:

- **Sara: 2 actions (Pass).**
- **Skyler: 2 actions (Pass).**
- **Tommy: 4 actions** (Fail — extra step required for text input/setup).

Average: 2.7 actions.
Verdict: Partial Success. The flow meets the target for most users, but required text input pushes non-desk users like Tommy over the ≤3-action threshold.

Testing Results: Goal 2: Support without pressure

Sentiment ratio

Metric: Ratio of Positive vs. Negative emotional comments during "Think Aloud".
Target: Greater than 2:1 Ratio (More support than pressure).
Results:

- **Positive Comments (9):** "It's cute," "Feels like a buddy," "Less lonely".
- **Negative Comments (3):** "Blocking my screen," "I hate typing," "What does this button do?"

Ratio: 3:1.
Verdict: Success. Users validated the "Low-Pressure Presence" hypothesis, confirming the companion reduces isolation without adding stress.

Intrusion incidents

Metric: Intrusion incidents ("blocks my work" moments)
Target: 0 intrusion incidents (Never block work).
Results:

- **Sara: 0 incidents (Pass).**
- **Skyler: 1 incident (Fail).**
- **Tommy: 0 incidents (Pass).**

Total: 1 intrusion incident.
Verdict: Needs Improvement. Even a single obstruction event undermines "support without pressure," motivating Smart-Dodge + Transparency controls in GR6.

Changes Needed to Hit Goals

Goal 1: Reduce startup friction

- Replace manual timer setup with one-click Quick-Start Presets (directly addresses Tommy's 45s / 4-action failure)
- Add voice-to-task input for users who dislike typing
- Target: bring ALL users under 30s and ≤3 actions

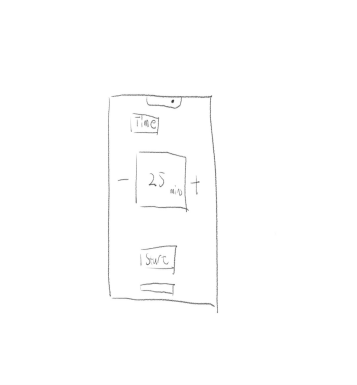
Goal 2: Support without pressure

- Implement Smart Dodging / Transparency Mode so the companion never obstructs active tools (directly addresses Skyler's 1 intrusion incident)
- Redesign pause state to be emotionally neutral ("Pudding naps"). Sara felt "judged" and guilty when pausing
- Lock customization features until after a completed focus session to prevent "productive procrastination" (Skyler spent 4 minutes customizing outfits before starting work)

Change #1: One-Click Quick-Start Presets

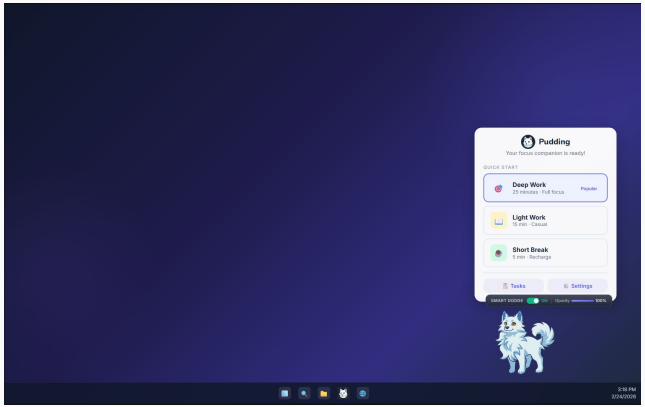
Previously

User had to set up a timer manually, selecting duration, typing task name, before starting. Tommy found this "setup work" exhausting (45 seconds, 4 actions), which increased the emotional barrier to starting.



Now

The main desktop widget features Quick-Start Presets. One click on "Deep Work" immediately spawns Pudding and starts a 25-minute timer. No typing, no setup decisions.



Change #1: How this addresses testing feedback:

Testing Data

- Tommy's 45s startup time → reduced to 1 click (~5s)
- Tommy's 4 actions → reduced to 1 action
- Directly addresses Usability Goal 1 (Reduce Startup Friction): targets both time-to-start (<30s) and interaction cost (≤3 actions)

Observation

Tommy took 45 seconds and 4 actions in testing (the only participant to fail both Goal 1 measurements), primarily due to required text input before starting.

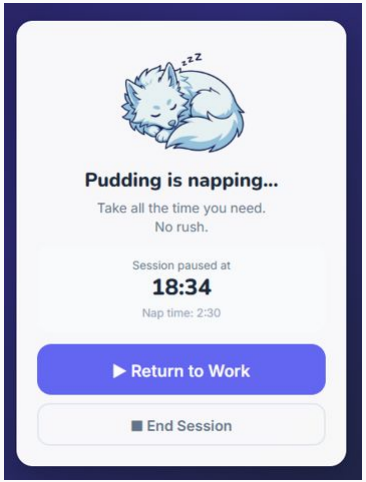
Change #2: Neutral "Nap" State for Pausing

Previously

Pausing the session showed the companion looking sad, which made Sara feel "judged" and guilty. She said: *"I felt bad pausing him... like I was abandoning my study buddy."* This emotional penalty triggered the Anxiety Loop rather than supporting recovery.

Now

When the user pauses, Pudding enters a neutral "Nap" state. The companion curls up and sleeps. No negative emotion. A clear "Return" button makes re-entry obvious and guilt-free.



Change #2: How this addresses testing feedback:

Testing Data

- Sara's "guilt pause" → eliminated by neutral emotional tone
- Directly addresses Usability Goal 2 (Support Without Pressure): prevents negative sentiment that would worsen the sentiment ratio
- Supports our design value of "gentle re-entry rituals"

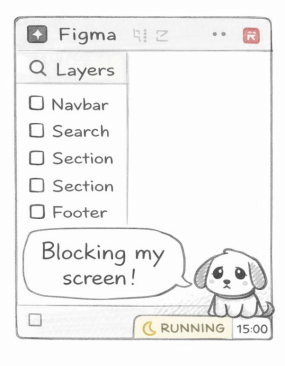
Observation

Sara visibly hesitated when the nudge appeared, joking she felt "judged" by the character. The sad pause state was the primary source of negative emotional friction in testing.

Change #3: Smart Dodging / Transparency Mode

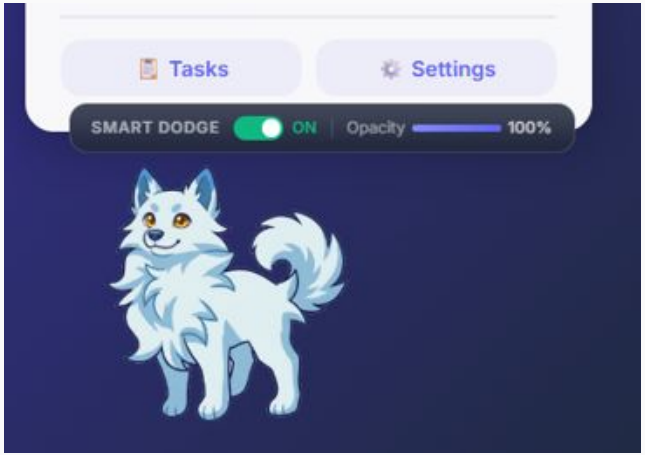
Previously

The desktop companion was always visible on screen with no awareness of what apps the user had open. During testing, Skyler repeatedly tried to drag the companion character off her Figma layers panel because it was blocking her professional workspace.



Now

The companion detects active windows and either auto-dodges (moves away from the active tool's panels) or can be set to a transparency slider so it remains a subtle presence without obstructing work.



Change #3: How this addresses testing feedback:

Testing Data

- Skyler's 1 intrusion incident ("blocking my screen") → eliminated by auto-dodge behavior
- Directly addresses Usability Goal 2 (Support Without Pressure): intrusion target is 0 incidents
- Addresses value tension: ambient presence must coexist with professional workflows

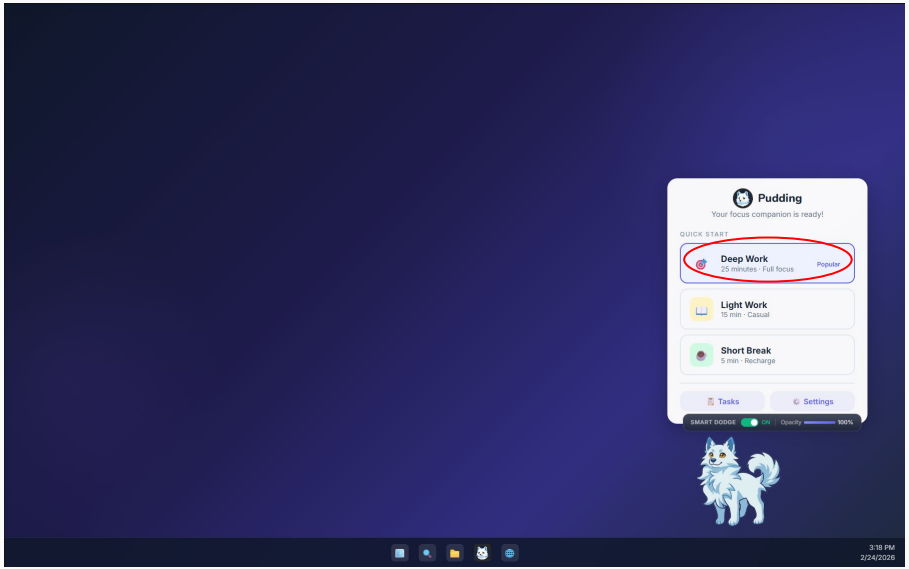
Observation

Skyler was the only participant with an intrusion incident. She repeatedly tried to drag the companion away from her layers panel during the desktop test, showing the companion's positioning was disruptive to real workflows.

Medium-Fi Task Flow - Simple

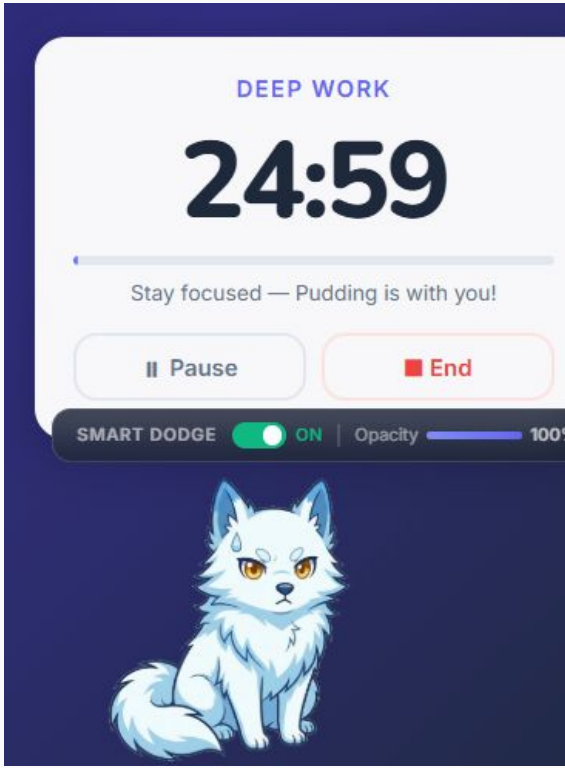
User clicks "Deep Work" on the home widget. Timer starts immediately.
Total: 1 action, ~5 seconds.
Addresses Goal 1 (Reduce Startup Friction): 1 click, <30s, ≤3 actions

Screen: Home Widget



Click 'Deep Work'"

Screen: Timer Running, STATE: RUNNING



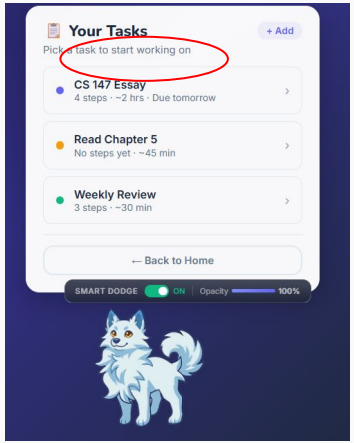
Timer starts, Pudding focuses"

Medium-Fi Task Flow - Moderate

User selects a task, reviews steps, then starts Step 1.
Total: 3 screens, lightweight planning before starting.

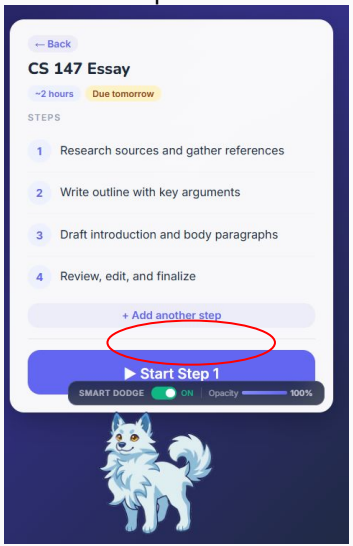
Addresses Goal 1: Lightweight planning reduces friction while keeping progress visible

Screen: Task List



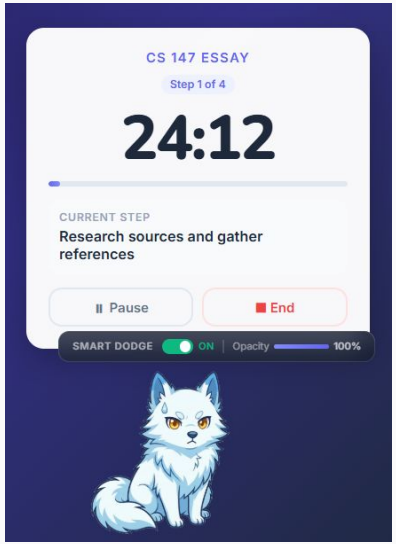
Select task

Screen: Step Editor



Review steps

Screen: Running



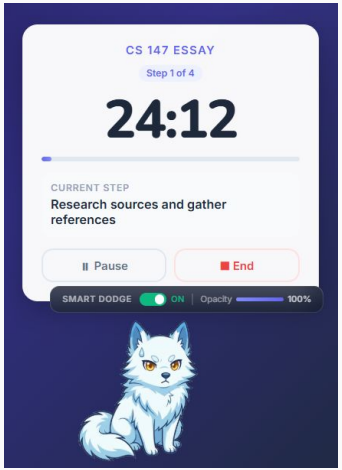
Step 1 running

Medium-Fi Task Flow - Complex

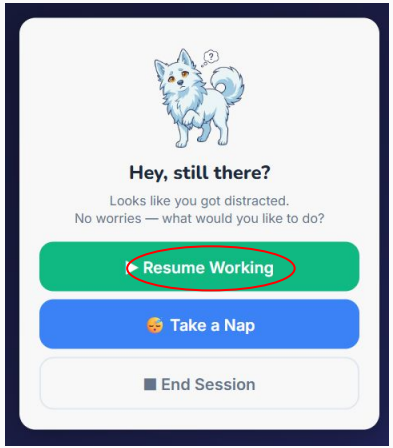
Companion detects distraction, offers 3 recovery paths.
After ending, user reflects and sets a next step.

Addresses Goal 2 (Support Without Pressure): Neutral recovery options eliminate guilt

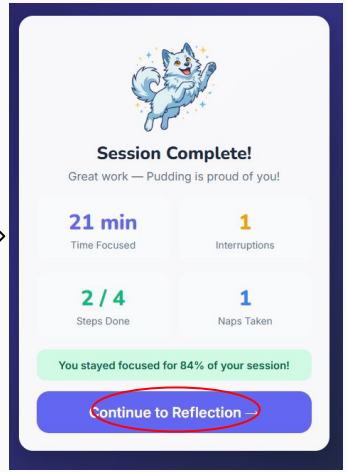
Screen: Running



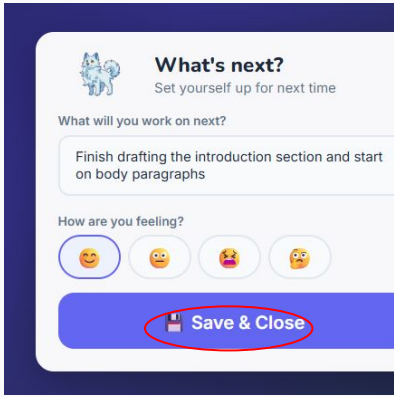
Screen: Nudge Overlay



Screen: Summary



Screen: Reflection



Session stats → Distraction detected → End session → "What's next?" closes the loop

Multi-path: RUNNING → NUDGED → NAP/ENDED → REFLECTION

Prototype Limitations

Feature	How It's Simulated	Why
Quick-Start Presets	Only "Deep Work" (25 min) is clickable; other presets are visual-only	One working preset is enough to test the core simple task
Task List	Pre-populated with 2–3 hard-coded tasks	No backend needed; focuses testing on navigation and comprehension
Step Editor	"Break into steps" populates template steps; limited free typing	Tests the step-breaking flow without introducing heavy text input friction
Companion States	Pudding states are static images swapped between screens (no real animation)	Prototype can test emotional tone, but not real-time motion behavior
Smart Dodging / Transparency	Dodge bar is shown, but companion placement is manually non-obstructive (no window detection)	OS-level window awareness isn't possible in a prototype
Nudge Trigger	Nudge overlay appears via a user hotspot, not true idle/off-task detection	Lets us test recovery choices without implementing detection logic
Timer	Countdown is represented with static timestamps (not real-time)	Prototype limitation; flow testing does not require a live timer
Reflection Input	"What's next?" field is visual-only; "Save" navigates to a pre-built updated screen	No data persistence; still tests whether users understand closure + next step

Impact on Goals: Hard-coded presets may make startup feel faster than production (no loading or setup). Static companion images can't fully test whether real-time motion feels supportive vs. distracting. **Smart Dodging is the biggest gap** — Skyler's intrusion incident was our only Goal 2 failure and cannot be evaluated in this prototype.

Appendix -> Link to Figma and Link to README.

Figma

https://www.figma.com/proto/fCykx9BqDVUzOD48LjTsq9/Pudding-Medium-Fidelity-Prototype?node-id=94-62&t=7IyJfZmlNLhDqKJJ-1

README

https://docs.google.com/document/d/1zwqs9OjoEpOb51JcWY5DPqSLF2tAbrBY2S4GhO2_nr4/edit?usp=sharing